

EXECUTIVE DATA ANALYSIS REPORT

The Impact of Generative Artificial Intelligence on Higher Education Cohorts

A Data-driven Investigation into Student Performance, Operational Workflows, Tool Equity, and Well-being Metrics across 50,000 Sample Profiles.

Prepared By: Barnabas Nartey (Data Analyst & Telecom Engineer)

Project Domain: Academic Analytics & Full-Stack AI Optimization Labs

Dataset Size: 50,000 Complete Active Student Records

Report Date: May 2026

1. Executive Summary & Core KPIs

This comprehensive analytical report details the empirical findings extracted from the **Generative AI Student Impact Evaluation Framework**. Leveraging data from a cohort of 50,000 university students, this analysis uncovers a multi-faceted dynamic: while Generative AI technologies serve as a significant catalyst for GPA improvement and operational study efficiency, unchecked reliance introduces measurable risks regarding exam anxiety, tool dependency, and potential skill degradation.

The dataset establishes that the average baseline student utilizes GenAI tools for approximately **8.43 hours per week**, contrasting with **11.21 hours** of traditional, independent study. Crucially, the holistic cohort achieved a net positive mean academic progress of $\Delta GPA = +0.203$ points over the evaluation cycle.

50,000

STUDENT COHORT

8.43 hrs

AVG GENAI/WEEK

+0.203

MEAN GPA DELTA

75.80%

SKILL RETENTION

Core Analytical Paradigm

The data indicates that academic success is not a function of the absolute time spent using AI tools, but rather a function of the **Prompt Engineering Skill Level** and the specific **Primary Use Case**. Advanced prompt skills yield a 33.9% higher GPA improvement rate compared to beginners.

2. Academic Performance Breakdown by Discipline

Analyzing the impact across academic specializations reveals that **STEM** (Science, Technology, Engineering, and Math) disciplines experience both the highest tool adoption metrics and the highest corresponding academic benefits. STEM students averaged **10.49 weekly GenAI hours**, capturing a substantial average GPA growth of **+0.217**.

Major Category	Student Count	Weekly GenAI Hours	Pre-Semester GPA	Post-Semester GPA	Average GPA Change	Skill Retention Score
STEM	15,059	10.49 hrs	3.15	3.36	+0.2173	76.80%
Medical	6,476	7.55 hrs	3.14	3.35	+0.2014	75.48%
Humanities	9,994	6.77 hrs	3.15	3.34	+0.1980	75.25%
Arts	5,933	7.27 hrs	3.14	3.34	+0.1969	75.66%
Business	12,538	8.28 hrs	3.15	3.34	+0.1943	75.26%

Conversely, **Business** students demonstrated the lowest average GPA enhancement (**+0.1943**) despite registering relatively high utilization rates (8.28 hours/week). This points toward a structural gap in tool optimization or content alignment within business curricula.

3. The Prompt Engineering Skill Divide

A definitive insight within the dashboard data is the profound correlation between a student's technical command over AI interaction—specifically measured via **Prompt Engineering Skill Levels**—and final outcomes.

Prompt Skill Level	Cohort Count	Avg GenAI Hours	Average GPA Change	Skill Retention Score
Advanced	13,809 (27.6%)	8.69 hrs	+0.2481	82.05%
Intermediate	17,696 (35.4%)	8.37 hrs	+0.1869	75.82%
Beginner	18,495 (37.0%)	8.29 hrs	+0.1852	71.10%

Students possessing **Advanced Prompt Engineering Skills** achieved a spectacular mean GPA increase of **+0.2481** alongside an outstanding **82.05% Skill Retention Score**. This clarifies an essential mechanism: skilled users write prompts that encourage iterative learning, deep explanations, and problem decomposition, rather than copying flat output.

In stark contrast, **Beginners** spend roughly the same amount of weekly time on platforms (8.29 hours) but reap significantly diminished GPA growth (+0.1852) and suffer a degraded skill retention baseline of 71.10%.

4. Workflow Analysis: High-Value vs. Low-Value Use Cases

The data identifies a bifurcation based on what students ask AI tools to perform. The primary use case determines whether the technology serves as an intellectual amplifier or an educational crutch.

- **Debugging & Troubleshooting (12,295 Students):** Leads the entire cohort with a remarkable average GPA growth of **+0.2491** and a skill retention score of 78.07%. This reflects active learning, where students submit flawed material to isolate structural logic failures.
- **Copywriting & Drafting (12,011 Students):** Yields balanced progress (**+0.2004** GPA change, 75.23% retention) by accelerating content structural frameworks.
- **Ideation & Brainstorming (10,721 Students):** Serves as a solid conceptual companion, driving a steady **+0.1999** increase.
- **Direct Answer Generation (6,340 Students):** Registers as the most high-risk workflow. Students using AI for raw output retrieval achieved an average GPA change of only **+0.1335**—nearly 46% lower than the debugging cohort—and experienced heavily degraded memory and skill retention metrics (73.72%).

5. Psychological Dynamics & Burnout Risk Profiles

Accelerated AI exposure carries hidden institutional costs concerning mental health and cognitive dependency. Cross-tabulating weekly tool hours against perceived psychological strain reveals an aggressive inflection point where tools become counterproductive.

Burnout Risk Level	Cohort Count	Avg GenAI Hours	Exam Anxiety Level (1-10)	Perceived AI Dependency (1-10)	Average GPA Change
High Risk	12,487	15.21 hrs	4.89 / 10	4.64 / 10	+0.1956
Medium Risk	21,144	7.35 hrs	4.17 / 10	3.36 / 10	+0.2098
Low Risk	16,369	4.64 hrs	3.93 / 10	2.82 / 10	+0.2004

Students classified under the **High Burnout Risk** segment exhibit a high mean usage metric of **15.21 hours per week**. This extensive exposure is linked to elevated Exam Anxiety (4.89) and Perceived Dependency (4.64). Critically, this excessive usage results in diminishing returns, as their average GPA change drops to +0.1956—falling below the more moderate Medium Risk cohort (+0.2098) who utilize tools for just 7.35 hours per week.

The Diminishing Returns Threshold

Excessive reliance (>15 hours/week) triggers an optimization trap where heightened dependency and structural exam anxiety actively erode the performance advantages gained from the AI tools.

6. Impact of Institutional Alignment & Policies

The data reveals a critical message regarding policy framework constraints. Prohibitive stances do not stop tool usage; instead, they compromise student performance.

- **Allowed with Citation (25,224 Students):** Represents the most successful framework, resulting in the highest average GPA expansion of **+0.2080** and standard, stable exam anxiety metrics (4.12).
- **Actively Encouraged (14,988 Students):** Yields parallel benefits with a **+0.2057** GPA increase and an optimized exam anxiety floor of 4.11.
- **Strict Ban (9,788 Students):** Proves counterproductive. Under strict bans, students still recorded **8.37 hours of weekly usage** (almost identical to permissive environments). However, because they are forced to use tools covertly without peer or faculty guidance, their GPA expansion dropped to the lowest level (**+0.1870**) while their exam anxiety surged to a high of **4.89 out of 10**.

7. Strategic Recommendations

Based on the data extracted from the models, the following institution-wide modifications are recommended:

1. **Embed Structured Prompt Engineering in Core Curricula:** Because advanced prompt engineering bridges the gap to high skill retention (82.05%) and optimal GPA returns (+0.2481), institutions should run mandatory workshops to transition students out of beginner methodologies.
2. **Discourage 'Direct Answer' Models in Favor of Generative Debugging:** Faculty should redesign assignments to prioritize logical analysis and debugging tasks, which correlate with top-tier academic growth, while actively penalizing flat, unverified copy-paste behaviors.
3. **Abolish De Jure Prohibitive Bans:** Strict bans do not limit exposure; they simply penalize students psychologically, driving up exam anxiety to 4.89 and dampening potential GPA growth. Formalized, citation-based frameworks maximize transparent learning.
4. **Establish Exposure Red-Flags for Student Well-being:** Student advising divisions should monitor excessive usage patterns exceeding a 12-to-15-hour weekly threshold to mitigate localized burnout risk factors.